Mid-Life Crisis of Dionysus

By Garrison Keillor

INTRODUCTION

Dionysus, the god of wine and of orgies, the bastard son of Zeus and Semele. Dionysus the god of great parties- to his complete surprise one sunny afternoon suddenly became fifty years of age. He was reclining in his temple on Mount Cithaeron in Boeotia, enjoying a very fine 1925 B.C. Pinot Noir . . . when . . . it hit. . .

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DIONYSUS: **(Pgs 87-102)** That orgy tonight- I donno. I've laid in six gallons of extra virgin cold-pressed olive oil. You think that's too much or not enough? We'll have about fourteen nymphs and six satyrs and maybe a couple other gods, and some Macedonian guys

ARIADNE: Dionysus thought about this, and then he heard the sound of the sensible shoes of the Muse of Maturity, Gladys, coming up the steps and into his temple. *[GLADYS enters]*

GLADYS: Okay. Gramps, put down the beverage. I got news for you. You're fifty.

DIONYSUS: Fi-fi-fi-fi-fi-fi

GLADYS: That's right. Say it. Fifty.

DIONYSUS: Wait a minute. I'm immortal! Ageless! You can lookit up in any mythology!

GLADYS: Everybody gets just so much immortality and then it's time to grow up. You were young for thousands of years, like everybody else, and now you're fifty. What's the problem?

DIONYSUS: How can I be fifty? I'm Dionysus, the god of revels, the patron of satyrs, nymphs, Amazons, bull-roarers, madwomen in mink coats, I'm not just a wine kind of guy, I'm the guy who invented wine- I'm the god of wine, hey? I'm not ready to be fifty. I want more. Where'd she go? I'm not ready to be a geezer. I want more oysters! More wine in the wineskins! More women! Young women- slender- -long-legged. I'm not ready to sit in a sunny corner with a knitted comforter on my lap and chuckle. I want to get into trouble.

GLADYS: I got two words for you, mister. And that's grow up. Okay? Grow up. Happy birthday.

[GLADYS turns to stand alongside ARIADNE]

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ARIADNE: Dionysus decided to forget everything she said, and he got himself ready for the orgy that night.

GLADYS: He sat naked in the steambath, and his hands looked old, mottled, with big ropy veins, the skin wrinkly and rough, like a lizard's. DIONYSUS rises from the chair, dismayed.

ARIADNE: He looked into a pool and saw his reflection. Big tufts of hair poked from his ears, and his jawline looked very poorly defined - his chin seemed not so much to thrust forward as to be part of his neck. His neck looked poochy. His chest seemed to have descended about five inches.

DIONYSUS: Who did this to me?

NYMPH: Hey. You don't look that bad for fifty. Your back looks youthful. Sort of.

DIONYSUS: *[groans and turns, agonized]* Get out of here. *[The NYMPH exits, grunting. DIONYSUS faces the audience and turns an invisible key in the ignition, makes a starter sound, and steers the invisible wheel]*

ARIADNE: So Dionysus drove home to the suburbs of Boeotia, listening to oldies on the radio, and thinking about the terrible fate that had befallen him. When he got home, I was there waiting for him. I'm his wife. *[To DIONYSUS]* Hi, honey. You tired? You look beat.

DIONYSUS: Somebody else told me that too.

ARIADNE: I fixed you some poached grouper for supper, and a papyrus salad. High in fiber, honey. Time you started thinking about that sort of thing.

DIONYSUS: Oh.

ARIADNE: We need to talk about your drinking, Dionysus. You're drinking way too much. I want you to stop. Give it up. Please. For me and for the kids but most of all for yourself.

DIONYSUS: Look, I'm Dionysus. Okay? I'm the god of wine, okay? I'm not the god of iced tea, babes. *[agitated, he paces]*

ARIADNE: I knew you were going to say that.

DIONYSUS: I am the god of revelry, and revelry is no idle thing, it is a crucial element of the whole fertility process. The dancing and the whirling and the drinking and the shouting and the ecstatic singing and whooping- that's what makes the wheat grow, babes.

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ARIADNE: I'm concerned about your health, Dionysus. I read an article that said most people drink to build up self-confidence and compensate for low self-esteem. Maybe you need to see someone.

DIONYSUS: I have no lack of self-esteem! I'm a god!

ARIADNE: Are you? You're fifty, Dionysus. To me, fifty means mortal.

DIONYSUS: C'mon. I'm the same beautiful guy with the same flowing locks, as when you married me. Look. *[takes a lock of his hair and stares at it, cross-eyed, disappointed]*

ARIADNE: Drinking all that wine is hard on your hair, honey. And it causes loss of memory. And it makes you flatulent. *[He turns away – a loud fart. He jumps slightly]*

ARIADNE: I love you, Dionysus. Go see a doctor. Please. *[exits]*

GUY: *[enters, wearing a stethoscope and white jacket]* Say Ah. *[pokes a thermometer in Dionysus' mouth]*

DIONYSUS: Ahhhhhhhh-rghhhhhhhhhhhh!

GUY: *[raps on his chest, listens with the stethoscope, looks in both ears, takes out thermometer and reads it]* Okay. Not bad. Not bad. Your prostate's a little enlarged but you should be able to get a few more years out of it. Brain function seems fairly sound, considering. You're no gem, but you're in good shape. I'd say you ought to live well into your senility and beyond. *[GUY exits. DIONYSUS turns his back to audience]*

GLADYS: *[enters and addresses the audience]* Dionysus did not slept well that night. He dreamed terrible dreams about his mother, and he awakened four or five times to go downstairs and urinate. The next morning, he drove to the airport to fly to Mount Olympus to discuss the mortality problem with Zeus, his father, and to his great surprise, he got bumped off the first flight and put on stand-by. *[exits]*

DIONYSUS: What's going on here? I'm a god. I'm supposed to get the automatic upgrade, go right into first class.

NYMPH: Sorry, sir. First class is full [and] your deity card has expired. Expired yesterday.

DIONYSUS: Gods don't expire. It's an eternal thing.

NYMPH: I'm sorry, but this card is going to have to be renewed before we can upgrade you. I'll get you on the 4: 15 if I can.

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DIONYSUS: Please. *[turns away, pacing in frustration]*

NYMPH: *[comes downstage and addresses the audience]*Dionysus got on the 4: 15 flight, in tourist, a middle seat, between a man possessed of demons and a leper- it was the best we could do-- and when he finally arrived at Olympus, Zeus kept him waiting another hour. *[GUY enters, wearing a crown, robe, golden slippers, and carrying a scepter]*

DIONYSUS: Hi, Dad. Good to see you!

GUY: Son, I've decided to make a change. Latromis is going to become the god of wine, and you're going to be the chairman of wine. He'll do the revels and orgies and lie around with the nubile young women and you can organize wine programs, go to wine meetings. Maximize wine. And by the way, congratulations on turning fifty. I meant to send a card, but anyway, your birthday present is in there. *[waves toward the wings. DIONYSUS exits and returns with a handful of ordinary things]*

DIONYSUS: A sack of apples, and a pound of cheese? And what's this?

GUY: It's a souvenir photograph of me – autographed!

DIONYSUS: Dad? Why am I fifty? Why did my deity card expire? I thought I was going to be a god forever.

GUY: What? You? Fifty? Gosh. You don't look that old. Listen. I'll look into it. I'll get back to you. Okay? Great. Happy birthday. Bye. *[GUY exits]*

NYMPH: *[to the audience]* So, Dionysus went up to Mount Aesculapius where Theros, the muse of caring, ran a treatment program for gods.

GLADYS: *[enters, wearing a clinical jacket]* Lie down on the couch, Dionysus. Why don't we start from the beginning. Tell me about your parents.

DIONYSUS: You know about my parents. It's a famous story. My dad was Zeus, the Father of Heaven, the Head God, and he was fooling around with mortal women, and he fell in love with my Mom and then his wife Hera got jealous and- you know

GLADYS: So Hera came to your mom in disguise and said, "Hey, congratulations, but if you want a really good time, tell him to bring his thunderbolts, it's a real charge." And while they were engaged in passionate embrace, she caught on fire, right?

DIONYSUS: Right. Exactly.

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GLADYS: And your dad snatched you up from the ashes of her burning body and he sewed you up in his thigh and you spent most of your prenatal period there, in Zeus's left leg. After you were born, your mom's sister Ino tried to protect you, but Hera, your dad's wife, was still consumed with jealousy. She had you torn into shreds and boiled in a steaming cauldron.

DIONYSUS: Yes.

GLADYS: And you were rescued by your grandma, who put you back together, but you never forgot what happened, did you, Dionysus? You've never really come to terms with it, have you.

DIONYSUS: With being torn to shreds and boiled? No, I guess I haven't.

GLADYS: Maybe that's why you invented wine. Maybe it was an escape from the terrible disapproval of your wicked stepmother . . . How old are you?

DIONYSUS: I'm a god. I'm immortal.

GLADYS: I see. How long have you considered yourself a god?

DIONYSUS: Oh shut up. Would you? Just shut your mouth. You're dumber than dirt I don't "consider" myself a god. I **am** a god!

GLADYS: I'd like to talk about your anger right now.

DIONYSUS: I'm not angry, You are. I'm actually having a very good life. Wine and love and laughter and a certain measure of tasteless excess and sensual adventure- I've got a darned good life. Life is a celebration. And I'm one of the celebrants.

GLADYS: Oh, that's priceless. That really is. *[writes in her notebook]* You're the god of cliche.

DIONYSUS: Life **is** a celebration. Before we can create anything, we need to enjoy who we are now. Before you can get to tomorrow, you have to enjoy today. A person's most fundamental obligation in life is to enjoy it.

GLADYS: *[writing rapidly]* Not so fast, I want to get this down.

DIONYSUS: The great killer isn't foolishness, it's sullen lethargy and depression, that's what kills off the corn crop; but if you can bring yourself to sing, have a little wine, fix a nice dinner, tell some jokes, have a good time, spend some of your treasure on happiness, it makes the fields fertile, and we make more beer and whiskey, and life goes spinning on. *[DIONYSUS exits]*

GLADYS: *[to audience]* Dionysus did not bother to renew his deity card. He waited for Zeus to do something about it. Months and months passed and there was no word from the Father of

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Heaven and finally Dionysus just forgot about the whole thing. He just went on being whatever he was.

NYMPH: *(to audience)* His hair improved slightly, when he switched to a milder shampoo. He switched to a new brand of breakfast cereal. He bought a Nautilus machine.

ARIADNE: *(to audience)* He cut down on the wine and he learned to enjoy the ordinary. He learned how to take a deep breath, look at the woods, and think his own long thoughts.

GUY: *(to audience)* But he missed those wild orgies, those young women, the dancing, the love-making. As the chairman of wine, he'd fly off to conferences on "Meeting the Vine Needs of the Nineties" and give a long boring speech on "Maximizing the Total Wine Experience," a real stink bomb, and it only made him remember how much fun those orgies had been. He used to spend time with nymphs and satyrs, singing dirty songs and chasing virgins through the tall grass, and now he spent time with people who sat and bored the shoes right off you, complaining about traffic congestion. He thought about a swimming pool surrounded by green grass in a forest- he had swum naked there at midnight surrounded by happy women who wanted to press their skin against his.

ARIADNE: What you're thinking.

DIONYSUS: I was thinking that I've lived for thousands and thousands of years, and it's only now, since I turned fifty, that I start to get the hang of it.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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